FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The Telangana assembly election has some distinct and exciting features to it. It is the only triangular contest among four big state polls. The mighty BJP is not a serious contender for winning this election. The Congress, a national party, is battling it out with a regional party that is hoping to get a third term. The head of that party, the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS), is no ordinary politician. He was the founder of the state in 2014—K. Chandrashekar Rao, who is commonly known by the acronym KCR. Also, strangely, these leading contenders accuse each other of being the B-team of the BJP, citing examples of specific individuals not being arrested by the central enforcement agencies for alleged crimes.

National politics has evolved into a grand bipolarity between the BJP and the Congress-led INDIA bloc. But KCR stands aloof, unattached to either side. A year ago, he envisioned himself as the fulcrum of a non-Congress, anti-BJP national alliance. That's when his party thought it fit to rename itself the Bharat Rashtra Samithi from Telangana Rashtra Samithi to signify its founder's vaulting ambitions. But the way the cookie crumbled after that goaded him into whittling down the scale of his ambitions back to home turf: Telangana. And like a medieval potentate with a modern vocabulary, he waxes confident as he shoots for a hat-trick in the November 30 assembly election. "Let me be straight. There is pro-incumbency in Telangana," he tells INDIA TODAY. "Like what happened with Mr Jyoti Basu and Mr Naveen Patnaik when they won many terms."



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Having won Karnataka earlier in the year, the Congress is eyeing a revival across its northern border in a former stronghold that seemed to have forgotten its old patron. It has positioned ace poll strategist Sunil Kanugolu, whose constituency by constituency assessments were a game-changer in Karnataka, to pull off an encore in Telangana. Its political self-projection repeats Karnataka too, with a package of six guarantees to win the support of women, farmers and even farm labour. Also invigorating its campaign on the ground is the feisty new state chief, Lok Sabha MP A. Revanth Reddy. An earthy, articulate, charismatic street fighter with an acerbic tongue, he has an old grudge against KCR for putting him in jail once. It won't be easy for the Congress, though, which has to bridge the 18.5 percentage point gap between its vote share of 28.4 per cent and the TRS's 46.9 per cent in 2018.

And the BJP, having lost Karnataka, badly wants to compensate itself in another southern state. Inexplicably, though, it seems to have turned off the heat on KCR. It replaced its firebrand state chief, Bandi Sanjay Kumar, four months ago. In September, the ED agreed not to summon KCR's daughter, ex-MP K. Kavitha, in the case relating to the Delhi liquor scam till her plea to the Supreme Court was heard. That case had by then become symbolic of two of the three sins KCR was being accused of: nepotism and corruption. The third, an authoritarian tendency, is, of course, not a novelty in Indian politics. Anyway, the impression gained ground that the BJP was going soft on KCR to thwart a Congress victory by ensuring the BRS is not weakened further. The BJP has been trying to correct that perception, with even Prime Minister Narendra Modi tearing into KCR at his rallies. However, their best prospect is a hung house, which denies the Congress a victory and the BRS short of a majority.

For KCR, any adverse outcome would be an aberration given his strikingly successful personal, political and administrative record over the last decade. Ever since his TRS broke off from the UPA around state formation days in 2014 and went defiantly solo, he has stayed an autonomous republic and a very prosperous one. His state has prospered under him. Telangana's nominal growth rate has averaged 12.7 per cent annually since its formation in 2014, 2.2 percentage points higher than the 10.5 per cent nominal growth projected for India for FY24. The state's per capita income has more than tripled, making it No. 1 among all big Indian states, a stark contrast to the national trend. So, judging by the macros, there's no real spur for anti-incumbency.

As the battlefield darkens before D-day, our cover story lays out the past, present and possible future of a remarkable personality and his administrative acumen. Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa travelled to the poll-bound state for a feel of the ground and, along with Senior Deputy Editor Amarnath K. Menon in Hyderabad, brings you exhaustive analysis and descriptive colour. KCR took time off from his campaigning to give them a rare exclusive interview at his sprawling farm on the outskirts of Hyderabad. His farming roots sustain not only his personal interests but also form the very leitmotif of his government. His pioneering farm investment support scheme Rythu Bandhu, often derided as a freebie, has produced highly creditable results. In the decade ending in 2022, Telangana shot to India's top with a 99 per cent growth rate in paddy output value. For a crop that takes standing water and that too in an arid state, that did not come out of the blue. KCR laid its foundations with a massive expansion in irrigation: beginning with Mission Kakatiya, named after the dynasty that built "a network of 75,000 interconnected tanks" over this province centuries ago, Telangana had registered a 117 per cent increase in gross irrigated area by 2022. No wonder KCR calmly accepts the charge of being an absolute ruler thus: "Centralisation is needed. KCR certainly decides on key issues because, as a founder of Telangana, I know the requirements of the state."

There can be various reasons why people may want a government voted out. The desire for change, for the sake of change, is not unknown. Increasing prosperity can also unlock social energies in unpredictable ways. Belonging to the Velama caste, with roots in the old zamindari system, KCR has not necessarily widened empowerment politics. Both his rival parties are picking on the gaps, the Congress by conspicuously widening the ambit of welfarism and the BJP going big on OBC candidates. They also pay him a backhanded tribute, though. No one promises to roll back his policies, only better them. But can KCR better his future? Also, the outcome of the Telangana election will be a barometer for the 2024 general election on whether a regional party with a strong leader can withstand the onslaught of two national parties.

(Aroon Purie)